

THE PRODUCTION CHEAT SHEET

Every stage of making Matter of Light as a task, with its subtasks sorted by colour: the steps to do, the settings to use, and the lessons the film taught. Nine stages, five gates, one loop.

B.L. Barkey · Higgsfield Global Film Festival 2026
38 steps · 27 settings · 29 lessons

 **Step** do it, tick it  **Setting** use this value  **Lesson** what the film taught  **GATE** a person checks a screen  the loop inside a stage

0 STORY 4 3 3	1 CAST 5 4 4	A 2 ANCHORS 4 2 3	B 3 STILLS REEL & TIMING 3 2 2	C 4 MOTION 5 4 4	D 5 VOICE & SOUND 4 3 3	E 6 THE CUT 5 3 4	7 DELIVER 4 3 3	8 LEARN 4 3 3
----------------------------	---------------------------	--	---	---	--	--	------------------------------	----------------------------

5:00 planned	5:43 on the board	6:17 delivered	23 shots planned	108 scenes in the cut	130 takes in the account	42 reference sheets	39 anchor frames	40 voice takes
------------------------	-----------------------------	--------------------------	----------------------------	---------------------------------	------------------------------------	-------------------------------	----------------------------	--------------------------

EVERY STAGE SETTINGS AT A GLANCE

The values that applied across the whole production.

◇ FORMAT Picture 21:9 · 1080p · 24 fps · mp4 Export 2560×1098 · H.264 CRF 17 · AAC 320 Video model cinematic_studio_videodeo_4_0, 8–16s Images nano_banana_2 · nano_banana_pro	◇ PROMPT GRAMMAR Attach @[name](uuid) for every face, place and thing Close with REFERENCES — attach before generating: ... Always No text, no captions, no logos anywhere in frame Never a described face, or a covering described negatively	◇ READING SCORES Strong overall 55 or more Watch 45 to 54 Weak under 45 Wander dmn_mean, lower is better; 0.5 or less is good	◇ THE DESK LOOP Ingest ingest.py admits this project's takes Score Predictor, every take ≤16s Build build.py lays board.html Choose pick and why in project.json Generate generate.py, only what is missing	◇ SAFETY Keys keys.env only; never in a prompt or a commit Names crosswalk.local.js stays local, never pushed Ages every sheet 18+; read every wide back Rights licence and visibility before the first push
---	---	--	---	---

THE DOCUMENTS MAKING THE BIBLE ITSELF

Lessons from keeping the Director's Bible and the repository, not the picture.

- When one list drives another, audit them against each other on every change. Parity drift is silent. - When state looks wrong, diff against the remote before acting. The fix was a fast-forward, not a new commit.	- Retire superseded work the moment its replacement exists. Keeping both is a decision left for later. - Every rung of an escalation must take something as well as give. If the ladder only goes up, the ending cannot land.	- State what was verified and what was not, in the document itself. - Regenerate, don't hand-edit. Every page is a function of its data; if the page is wrong, the data is wrong.
---	---	---

PHASE I BEFORE ANYTHING MOVES

Writing, identities and stills. Images are cheap; every mistake fixed here saves a video.

0

STORY

What is the film about, and who changes?

ON THE FILM Aug 8 – Sep 9 • 23 shots at 13.0s mean • 3 movements 80 / 118 / 102s • 12 lines, 89 words

STEPS 4

- ☐ **Write the logline first.** One sentence, ≤140 characters, three variants.
- ☐ **Cut the screenplay to shots at cinema length.** Mean 13s, not 4s sizzle. Motivate every cut by point of view, time or revelation.
- ☐ **Cut the dialogue to what a synthetic voice can carry.** 556 words became 89.
- ☐ **Name the turn.** The last held close-up belongs to whoever changes.

SETTINGS 3

- ◇ **Runtime target** 300s, split into three movements.
- ◇ **Silent shots** marked now: `audio: false` in the shot list.
- ◇ **Shot list** lives in `project.json → shots[]`; dialogue in `design/dialogue.json`.

LESSONS 3

- **A second sentence in the logline means a second film.**
- **The ending was reversed on Sep 14.** Rewriting only the last two shots kept everything upstream.
- **Check order and attribution against the source,** not just whether a beat is present.

🔄 **Iterate • The ending.** When the turn lands on the wrong character: rewrite the last two shots only.

1

CAST

Does every face, place and thing exist once, by id?

ON THE FILM Done Sep 5 • 42 sheets • 37 handles • 5 Souls (4 active) • 4 plates • 3 boards

STEPS 5

- ☐ **Write the rule sheets before any character.** Here, the aura rule and the attunement ladder.
- ☐ **Train one Soul per lead,** then generate every state sheet from it. Never re-describe a face.
- ☐ **One lighting plate per act,** plus one per exception, and one Canvas board per plate.
- ☐ **Locations, props, creatures, effects on a plain background,** three views on one sheet where it helps.
- ☐ **Record every id** and attach it as `@[name](uuid)` in every prompt from here on.

SETTINGS 4

- ◇ **Sheets** on `nano_banana_2` or `nano_banana_pro`.
- ◇ **Souls** on Soul Cast `soul_2`, budget 10–500. One Soul per generation; two-person shots run on elements.
- ◇ **Generate inside the project folder.** The API cannot file it for you.
- ◇ `retired` keeps old name → old id so old renders still attribute.

LESSONS 4

- **Never describe a covering by what it is not.** The filter read the disclaimer as the subject: two credits and an hour.
- **Record old → new the moment you swap an element.** Two swaps went unrecorded and four prompts pointed at dead ids.
- **Scores cannot see a wrong face.** All four S5 takes carried the mortal sheet.
- **File by what a thing is,** never by where it is used.

🔄 **Iterate • Identity.** When a face moved or a shot used a superseded sheet: retire the old id, regenerate from the Soul, sweep every prompt.

GATE A IDENTITY LOCK

All sheets on one screen in the canvas. Look for a face that moved, and record the answer.

2

ANCHORS

Does the film exist as stills, in order, that are already right?

ON THE FILM Skeleton Sep 6 • 39 anchors • 6 shared • 2 bridges • 3 match pairs

STEPS 4

- ☐ **Make the first and last frame of every shot,** in film order, on the plate's board. F01 should be almost nothing.
- ☐ **Chain each frame from the previous frame's job id,** not from its prompt.
- ☐ **Make a shared frame once, a bridge truly black, a match pair as a pair.**
- ☐ **Two passes on a prompt, then rewrite it.** Promote any draft that beats its anchor.

SETTINGS 2

- ◇ **No text, no letters, no watermark,** said three ways in every prompt.
- ◇ **Frame roles** in `design/anchor-plan.json`: single, shared, bridge, match.

LESSONS 3

- **Drift here costs an image; drift later costs a video.**
- **A bridge that is only 70% black** reads as a hidden cut that failed.
- **The selection pass is where the time goes,** not the skeleton: one generation per frame took a day, choosing took a week.

🔄 **Iterate • The frame.** When a composition will not survive its duration: two passes on the prompt, then rewrite.

GATE B STRING LOCK

Every frame on one contact sheet, read left to right twice. Anything that drifts is regenerated before a single video.

PHASE II

MAKING IT MOVE

Timing, motion and sound. After Gate C, a structural change costs video, not images.

3

STILLS REEL & TIMING

Does it play, at length, before anything moves?

ON THE FILM Planned Sep 9 · 300s target · 5:43 on the board · 6:17 delivered

☐ **STEPS 3**

- ☐ **Cut the stills at their durations and sit through the whole runtime.** Where attention drops, a shot is long or a cut is unmotivated.
- ☐ **Decide the structure now:** linear, prologue splice, fold or interlace. Price each in new anchors.
- ☐ **Freeze runtime, order and count,** and write the date down.

◆ **SETTINGS 2**

- ◆ **A structural fix moves an establishing beat,** not a scene: one new anchor at most.
- ◆ **Song first.** If the sound might be a song, lock it here and cut the stills reel to it.

● **LESSONS 2**

- **The cut followed three songs' lyrics.** The music-video rule applied and nobody noticed.
- **A zero-cost fix was never applied.** The brothers' beat was priced at one anchor; they first appear at 4:59.

↻ **Iterate • Structure.** When the peak lands early or the lead dies before we meet the ending's carrier: move an establishing beat.

GATE C

TIMING LOCK

Runtime, order and count frozen. Any change after this is a re-render.

4

MOTION

Is every shot a move between two frames that are already right?

ON THE FILM Sep 13 big run, 43 renders · 51 v4.0 renders Sep 10-14 · 2 of 16 chained

☐ **STEPS 5**

- ☐ **Pull the project's history before you spec a run.** Read what you are actually using.
- ☐ **Run a cheap pass on every shot first,** then finals per act.
- ☐ **Two takes per prompt, then rewrite.** A third take is a different prompt.
- ☐ **Chain start and end frames on anything over 12s,** from the rendered last frame, not the anchor still.
- ☐ **Score every take ≤16s.** Read the curve, not the number.

◆ **SETTINGS 4**

- ◆ `cinematic_studio_video_4_0` in the web app: 8-16s, 720p → 1080p, 21:9, renders 1344×576 at 720p.
- ◆ `minimax_h3` is the one API model with two frames, audio references, 21:9 and `folder_id`.
- ◆ **Audio off** on every shot marked silent, and on every regeneration of one.
- ◆ **Cost** about 5 min and one credit per 16s take at 1080p. Scoring is free, two at a time.

● **LESSONS 4**

- **The notes said v2, 12s, 720p. The account said v4.0, 16s.**
- **17 of 18 takes peaked on their last second,** so the hook score undersells a slow film.
- **Regenerations with audio on invented lines** ("Thank you", "I'm sorry.") in silent shots.
- **One generation per shot gave the editor one angle.** Plan coverage or montage before Gate D.

↻ **Iterate • The take.** When an identity break, a missing beat or an outlier score: regenerate only that, on the right sheet, then re-score and rebuild.

GATE D

MOTION LOCK

A pick per shot, chained where it must be, no identity break in any pick.

5

VOICE & SOUND

Is every sound in the project, and is every silence a decision?

ON THE FILM Sep 13 · 12 lines · 40 takes · 4 per line · 0.1 credit each

☐ **STEPS 4**

- ☐ **Cast two voices per character on the same line;** pick one and write it down.
- ☐ **Four takes per line** with the scene's mood. Keep the spec take as take 1.
- ☐ **Generate the voice first,** attach it as an audio reference, and turn the model's own audio off on that shot.
- ☐ **Upload every audio file into the project** and credit the music honestly on the end card.

◆ **SETTINGS 3**

- ◆ `seed_audio` 0.1 credit a line · speech rate -50 to 100 · pitch -12 to 12 · no seed.
- ◆ `qwen_audio_tts` has a real seed and an instruction field; `text2speech_v2` is ElevenLabs via Higgsfield.
- ◆ **Score** made in Suno's app, then uploaded. There is no API.

● **LESSONS 3**

- **Sound was the weakest region in 13 of 18 clips.** Put the first line under the first three seconds.
- **A silence rule cannot survive a lyric on the climax.** The vortex played under "In the sky!".
- **The opening narration existed** but was not under the black at submission.

↻ **Iterate • The read.** When a line reads flat or the tempo is wrong for the shot: one more take at ±12 speech rate, never more than four.

PHASE III FINISHING AND LEARNING

The cut, the submission, and the read of the delivered film against the board.

6

THE CUT

Which take, in what order, and why?

ON THE FILM Sep 14, 21:30-23:59 UTC · 22 picks · 21 favourites, 6 of them the board's alternates

STEPS 5

- ☐ **Decide the rhythm before you pick:** held frames, or montage to a song.
- ☐ **Pick by look, break ties by score,** and write why under each pick.
- ☐ **Keep the tail, trim the head.** 17 of 18 takes paid on their last second.
- ☐ **Favourite the pick of every shot as you lay it.** It is the only record the platform keeps.
- ☐ **Fix with edits before generations:** a split, a voice under black, a take swap.

SETTINGS 3

- ◆ **Timeline at the film's aspect before export:** 2560×1098 · 24 fps · H.264 CRF 17 · AAC 320.
- ◆ **Deliver at native size ×2 at most.** 1344×576 blown to UHD is eight times the pixels and soft.
- ◆ **End card:** generate the plate with no text, lay the type in the NLE, hold credits 12s or more.

LESSONS 4

- **Selection is the grade.** On S22 the chroma take scored 59, the flat take 49.
- **The board planned 23 shots at 13s; the cut ran 100 scenes at 3.7s.**
- **The excluded dragon takes became the 23s set piece.** Show excluded takes greyed, never hidden.
- **Five Orianes and two leviathans reached the cut.** Audit the timeline, not the board.

🔄 **Iterate · The cut.** When an arc, light or hook problem against the judges: three changes, one per judge, priced in generations.

GATE E PICTURE LOCK

No further generation. The export exists and plays end to end.

7

DELIVER

Does it count?

ON THE FILM Sep 14-17 · final MOV ~23:30 UTC · 3 loglines · 3 support addresses

STEPS 4

- ☐ **Read the rules again on the day,** and pass rights on every input: no real face or voice anywhere.
- ☐ **Apply watermark and packshot through the platform's own flow.** Never recreate them.
- ☐ **Post publicly from a public account** and check both in a private window.
- ☐ **Verify every generation is inside the project.** Submit. Then stop.

SETTINGS 3

- ◆ **Minimal viable submission** has two parts: watermark and packshot, and the public post.
- ◆ **Deadline in its own timezone.** Two records disagreed (UTC vs PT); work to the earlier one.
- ◆ **Public page:** higgsfield.ai/@drawingsquid1334/projects/matter-of-light

LESSONS 3

- **The submit flow put nine seconds of packshot at the head.** Check where it lands before the last export.
- **The full film exists once in the account,** as the Sep 16 MOV. Record which file went where, by id and date.
- **Ownership and exposure are different risks.** Ask what the submission publishes.

✓ **No loop.** This stage is a checklist.

8

LEARN

What did the cut change, and what does the next film inherit?

ON THE FILM Read Sep 29 · 108 scenes · 6:17 · 6 look-swaps · 0 credits

STEPS 4

- ☐ **Upload the master into the project root** and keep the low proxy beside it.
- ☐ **Start the scene analysis, then read favourites against picks** while it runs.
- ☐ **Diff order, durations, swaps, trims, drops and additions.** Price each as an edit or a generation.
- ☐ **Write each delta three ways:** a lesson, a reminder on the stage that could have caught it, an example.

SETTINGS 3

- ◆ `video_analysis_create` → `video_analysis_status`. About an hour in the queue on a 6:17 film.
- ◆ **The Predictor refuses anything over 16s,** and a 16s render is 16.05s. Score the 15s and 8s takes.
- ◆ `project.json` → `final` records the master, exports, analyses and where the read lives.

LESSONS 3

- **The cut overruled the board six times on look and never on score.**
- **The analyser read adult swimmers as children.** The 18+ rule is a per-take check on wides.
- **Of three last-hour changes,** one was applied, one half, one not.

🔄 **Iterate · The read.** When a finished film exists and the board disagrees with it: scenes → diff → three rules, then start the next board from them.